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A Fine Balance

Private initiative doesn't mean only corporate help, it involves citizens

The success of public-private participation in education depends on the design of the partnership. At the same time, there has to be a distinct definition of what is public and private. Private partnership doesn't just mean corporates giving money. It also means the citizens of India. It is believed that the Panchayati Raj system and the Gram Panchayat are powerful democratic units with the citizens of the village and community participating in education. I believe in that form of private partnership.

However, private participation currently means the corporate sector and donors funding education. This definition needs to be ap-

working in primary education—that is the responsibility of the government. But the same can be done for higher education where creators of knowledge are needed.

► It is important to also see whether the government's objectives are in sync with the private partners. There are times when private partners have their own vested interests. If you look at the Pratham model, it is a partnership that has worked well because it is a tripartite one. We work with the government, go to the corporates for our resources and use our technical know-how. The donors have left us alone to do our work but we do have the responsibility and accountability.

► Another question that needs to be asked is whether we are really reaching the target group. A lot of public schools are closing down in Mumbai and private schools are coming up. These schools are depriving the poorest of the poor of education because of high fees. We need to work out a system where there is equal education and equal access. One way of doing this is by ensuring that government schools provide good quality education. This can only happen if you insist on quality indicators and excellence. The myth is that poor people don't pay for education, therefore, their schools are bad. That's not true. The Mumbai Municipal Corporation spends about Rs 11,000 per year per child.

► It is important, therefore, to look at corporates as having a wider role than just that of donors. There are corporates who want to be involved in progress. Many come to Pratham and work or volunteer to teach and their employers pay the salary or protect their services.

► They can become champions for the cause, either by awareness drives or using their products to spread messages on health and education.

► They can help non-profit organisations in management. There are NGOs that have the will but lack management skills. That's how it works even with Pratham. Often we give corporates our data and they analyse it for us pro bono. Even in civil society, Pratham has thousands of volunteers who teach children and don't expect money in return.

That is the motivation needed. NGOs don't have the monopoly to change the world. And it is not only about the money. *As told to Chitra Subramanyam*

15%

of the schools in the country are privately owned and managed.

REUBEN SINGH



CORPORATE GROUPS CAN HELP NGOs TO LEARN MANAGEMENT SKILLS

proached with a little caution. There are many challenges to this.

► There is a need to design a public-private partnership better. The memorandum of understanding has to be clearly defined.

► The government and its systems are as large as its reach and resources. The private sector can help those systems work efficiently.

► The private sector can also go to those places where the government cannot.

► The private sector and the government should not be two parallel lines that will never meet. There should not be independent organisations